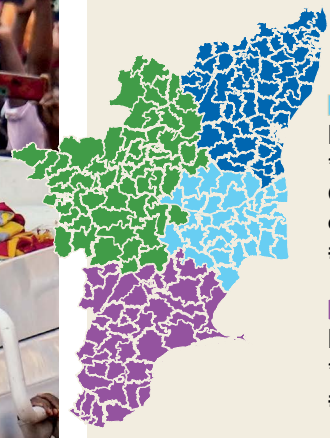


THE BATTLE ZONES

Kongu Nadu/Western Region (57)
*Gounders
#AIADMK

Northern Region (72)
*Vanniyars, Dalits
#DMK



Cauvery Delta (38)
*Vanniyars, Gounders, SC communities
#DMK

Southern Region (48)
*Thevars
#DMK

**Swing social groups; no. of seats ()*
#Dominant party in 2021 assembly poll

cal outfit and aligned with Pattali Makkal Katchi (PMK) founder S. Ramadoss, who finds himself set adrift by a faction led by his son Anbumani Ramadoss. The latter remains with the AIADMK-led alliance, which has allocated him 18 seats, second only to the BJP's 27. Sasikala's estranged nephew T.T.V. Dinakaran and his Amma Makkal Munnetra Kazhagam (AMMK) also extend their lodging within the NDA and will contest 11 seats.

Notably, smaller parties within the AIADMK alliance are contesting under the BJP's lotus symbol—an unusual move that may signal evolving political alignments. Many of them also defer to the BJP more than they do to the AIADMK. The saffron party has also stoked this perception, with their top national leaders avoiding naming EPS as the NDA's chief ministerial candidate. So it's easy to see why the AIADMK chief has repeatedly faced taunts that he has made the party subservient to the 'northern' BJP, what CM Stalin caustically calls "*adimai sasanam* (a slavery charter)".

Beyond the DMK-AIADMK binary, the one party that looks set to significantly influence voteshare dynamics is actor Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK). Some surveys suggest that it could secure a double-digit vote share—which would be an astonishing feat. Senior journalist and political commentator Priyan Srinivasan, though, says the political movement surrounding Vijay is inherently unpredictable.

The key question now is which party Vijay will damage most. "We only know massive crowds are following him everywhere. Will it take away the anti-DMK votes that go to the AIADMK? Will it take the minority votes that go to the DMK? Or will it take the youth votes that went to Seeman's Naam Tamilar Katchi (in 2021, the NTK had secured 6.6 per cent)? We don't know," notes Srinivasan.

Emerging Variables

Tamil Nadu's electoral politics continues to be shaped more by caste coalitions, regional alignments and welfare access than by religious polarisation. The DMK alliance traditionally draws support from the backward classes, Scheduled Castes, minorities and Periyarist segments of the urban voters.

Meanwhile, in western Tamil Nadu, the Kongu Vellala Gounders have historically backed the AIADMK. The region has become a critical battleground with recent inroads made by the DMK, but the AIADMK has a guarantee here with the presence of EPS, a Gounder. However, this identification complicates matters in the southern districts, where the Thevars, traditionally pro-AIADMK, look askance at their diminution in a "Gounder-centric" leadership. The tie-up with the AMMK, a heavily Thevar-based party, is meant to minimise that alienation. In the north, the Vanniyars hew close to the PMK; its split potentially fragments that.

Another emerging variable is the youth: the under-30 brigade account for one in five of all voters in Tamil Nadu (20.7 per cent or 11.7 million) and are a high energy cohort who tend to vote atypically. Last time around, they were swayed by the NTK's Tamil nationalist rhetoric; it could be Vijay who receives their benefaction this time.

Which is why political parties are putting in a lot of effort to expand their digital outreach. CM Stalin even has a Instagram-friendly reel programme, 'Vibe with MKS', where he has informal, non-political conversations with Gen Z representatives such as students, sportspersons and others. The DMK has also launched a grassroots campaign, 'Oraniyil Tamil Nadu', to enrol new voters.

Meanwhile, pre-election routines remain the same in the state. Both the DMK and AIADMK have tried to outbid the other in the freebies-for-voters game, starting from fridges to cash doles and vouchers to loan waivers and extensive subsidies. The Opposition parties have also made law and order, including the increasing cases of police malfeasance, a central campaign plank.

The 2026 election holds transitional potential for Tamil Nadu. The Dravidian parties still dominate, but new players and a national party are slowly muscling in. For the DMK-led alliance, the challenge is to ensure the 'Dravidian model' continues to resonate electorally; for the AIADMK-led side, it is to consolidate the anti-incumbency sentiment. And all parties must brace for whatever disruption Vijay's TVK brings. Whichever way the cards fall, the 2026 verdict is sure to shape the trajectory of Tamil Nadu's politics for years to come. ■